and fifteenth days of the moon, the first day after the full moon, on days of fasting and during the rainy season (the period of ‘chaturmasya’ being July to September). Many of these days are connected with the breeding habits of fish. Several fish breed in the rainy season beginning in July and usually lasting till September.[39] This is well recognized. What is less known is that there is also a lunar rhythm to the spawning of some freshwater fish such as carp and the ‘hilsa’, with new-moon and full-moon periods being most favourable.[40] On the basis of these injunctions, various calculations have been made about the number of such ‘fish-prohibition’ days, ranging from fifty-one to seventy-two, not a small number even if the days are spread over the whole year.

There is in the edict the combination of an extraordinary sensitivity to protecting the natural breeding patterns of living creatures while accepting that their slaughter will continue. An emperor pleading to his people to spare pregnant and lactating she-goats, ewes, and sows needs to say nothing else to appear extraordinary. The young of these animals, below the age of six months, were to be protected when their herds were culled for slaughter. Branding horses and bullocks is frowned upon, with a series of days specified when such cruelty is prohibited.

The prohibition days relating to Tishya, Punarvasu, and Chaturmasis are astrologically significant, Tishya and Punarvasu being lunar constellations which may have had some special significance for Ashoka. In the *Arthashastra* the two which were special constellations were supposed to be the birth-stars and consecration stars of kings (‘raja-nakshatra’ and ‘desha nakshatra’). Possibly, Tishya signified Ashoka’s birth-star and Punarvasu his anointment.[41] The Chaturmasis make sense in terms of the breeding season of fish, but there do not seem to be environmental reasons for forbidding the castration and branding of animals in that time slot. Basically, the provisions were instruments of control for reducing animal slaughter and cruelty. The purpose of stipulating days for such protective